officialdom thought of blaming urban agitators, and that is how blame came to be pinned on Lala Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh. Both of them were arrested and exiled. But the real cause was the conservative resistance of peasant farmers to an attempt to modernize them. And, there is modern-day equivalence in the passing of the three farm bills by the Modi government in 2020 as explained below. Back then, these farmers harboured a deep-seated resentment to the modern system of imposing fines for their failure to abide by the rules of sanitation, inheritance and resistance. The revolt was successful. Within five years, the Colony Act 1912 had abandoned state-controlled supervision of a system of modern progressive cultivation.

What is vital to note here is that the tumultuous political changes that began in 1907 did not end there and continued apace right through to 1947, and Bhagat Singh himself was not unaware or unaffected by them. The importance of the political changes is clear from Pandit Pearay Mohan's 'Punjab Rebellion' of 1919, [7] where he penned a memorable foreword to his valuable study of the epoch leading up to Indian Independence. He describes how the 1919 rebellion was preceded by such pivotal events in Punjab as 'the unrest of 1907, the historic trial of Arya Samajists in 1909, the prosecutions for sedition of 1909-1910, the conspiracy cases of 1913-1914, and the political trials held during the war'. [8]

It is true that during this time new forms of protest emerged as Gandhi's non-violent movement was beset with violent outbreaks. In the aftermath of these, Gandhi himself withdrew from agitational politics in the early 1920s. In Nagpur in 1925, Dr Keshav Baliram Hedgewar (also known as 'Doctor Ji') set up the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, (popularly known today as the 'RSS'), an Indian right-wing, Hindu nationalist organization which organized anti-British activities through the 'Kranti Dal' (the 'Party of Revolution'). But there is no doubt that the most notable of these was the Hindustan Socialist Republic Association, set up in 1929 by Chandrashekar Azad and Bhagat Singh, which forged ahead with a new, non-Gandhian approach in the fight for freedom. Although Chris Moffat is slightly critical of the emphasis historians have placed on Bhagat Singh's family inheritance, being more interested in his critical attitude towards them, there